RUB - INTRODUCTION TO LITERARY STUDIES

Literary Studies Concepts and Terminology Guide

Complete exam-focused revision without plot summaries, quotations or memorisation of assigned literary texts. All examples are invented and self-contained.

WHAT THIS PDF TESTS

Definitions, distinctions and the ability to apply a term to a short unseen example. It deliberately excludes questions such as who said a quotation, what happened in a specific work or which answer belonged to a named passage.

The four master questions

NARRATIVE

Who speaks? Then: **who perceives?** Keep narrator and focalization separate.

CHARACTERIZATION

Is the trait **stated or inferred?** Then: does the information come from the **narrator or a character?**

POETRY

Identify **voice, form, sound, line movement and devices**, then connect them to tone or theme.

DRAMA

Separate **spoken dialogue** from **performance instructions**, then identify speech form, genre and audience effect.

Fast study route

1. **Read pages 2-9** for the decision rules and high-risk distinctions.
2. **Use the glossaries** to check every term you cannot define in one clear sentence.
3. **Cover the right-hand columns** and recall definitions and recognition cues aloud.
4. **Finish with the self-check**; every prompt uses a generic example, not course-text memory.

Exam: Tuesday, 21 July 2026 - 16:15 - GABF 04/613

1 - Narrative architecture

CORE DISTINCTION

Story reconstructs what happened in chronological order. **Plot** is the event order presented by the text. **Discourse** is the broader how of narration, including perspective, selection, order and language.

The basic levels

Term	Meaning	Recognition question
Narrative	A representation of connected events communicated by a narrating instance.	Are events being presented through an act of telling?
Story	The reconstructed chronological sequence of events.	What happened first, next and last?
Plot	The concrete arrangement and connection of events as presented.	In what order does the reader receive events?
Discourse	The process and manner of storytelling.	How are order, perspective, language and information managed?
Narrator	The voice or instance that tells the story.	Who speaks or tells?
Person	The grammatical form, typically first or third person.	Which pronouns are used?

Setting, subject and theme

SETTING

The spatial, temporal and social environment. Ask **where, when and under what conditions** the action occurs.

SUBJECT

The broad topic, such as power, fear, identity, memory or conflict.

THEME

A developed claim or idea about the subject. It can usually be expressed as a full sentence.

TONE

The attitude conveyed toward the subject or audience through word choice, rhythm and style.

Reader effects

Term	Definition	Fast cue
Mystery	Interest created by missing information.	What happened? Who did it? Why?
Suspense	Anticipation about an uncertain future outcome.	What will happen next?

EXAM METHOD

Do not classify from one pronoun alone. First identify participation in the story world, then grammatical person, then information access.

2 - Narrator and focalization

TWO SEPARATE AXES
Narrator = who speaks? Focalization = **who perceives, knows, feels or reflects?** Any answer that treats these as identical is a trap.

Narrator position

Term	Definition	Key test
Homodiegetic narrator	The narrator is also a character in the story being told.	Does the narrating voice participate in the events?
Autodiegetic narrator	A homodiegetic narrator who is also the protagonist of the narrated story.	Is the narrator telling their own central story?
Heterodiegetic narrator	The narrator is not a character in the story world.	Does the voice remain outside the represented events?

Focalization

Type	Information available	Generic example
Internal	Restricted through a character's knowledge, perception, memory or feelings.	The narration gives Lena's worry and what she sees.
External	Limited to externally observable actions and details; no direct mind access.	Lena closes the door, pauses and looks away.
Zero	The narrator knows more than any one character and may move between minds, places or times.	The narration reports separate thoughts in distant rooms.

Common combinations

Combination	Possible?	What it looks like
Heterodiegetic + internal	Yes	Outside narrator, but information is restricted through one character's mind.
Heterodiegetic + external	Yes	Outside narrator reports only observable behaviour.
Homodiegetic + internal	Yes	A participating narrator reports personal perceptions and thoughts.
Homodiegetic + external	Yes, though unusual	An I-narrator temporarily reports only observable facts.

DO NOT CONFUSE
The **real author** creates the work. The **narrator** is a textual voice. The **focalizer** is the position through which information is selected.

3 - Characterization, presentation and time

Characterization uses two independent axes

Axis	First option	Second option
How direct?	Explicit: a trait is stated directly.	Implicit: a trait is inferred from speech, action, appearance or surroundings.
Who supplies it?	Narratorial: information comes from the narrator.	Figural: information comes through a character, including self-characterization.

COMBINATION RULE
An explicit statement can be narratorial or figural. An implicit clue can also be narratorial or figural. First decide **direct vs inferred**, then decide **narrator vs character**.

Modes of presentation

Mode	Function	Signal
Report	Summarizes actions or events.	Compressed sequence of what happened.
Description	Presents qualities, appearance, space or atmosphere.	Details about what something is like.
Narrative comment	Adds the narrator's judgement, reflection or direct address.	The telling voice pauses to evaluate or explain.
Speech / dialogue	Presents words spoken by characters.	Quoted or otherwise represented speech.
Free indirect discourse	Blends a character's idiom or viewpoint into third-person narration.	No reporting clause; character-like thought inside third-person form.
Interior monologue	Presents a character's thought more directly, often in first person and present tense.	Immediate thought flow with minimal narratorial framing.

Time and information

Term	Meaning	Cue
Analepsis	A backward movement to an earlier event.	Flashback.
Prolepsis	A forward movement or anticipation of a later event.	Flash-forward or advance notice.
Story time	The duration of events in the represented world.	How long do the events last?
Discourse time	The time or textual space used to present events.	How much text or reading time presents them?

4 - Poetry: voice, form and rhyme

Voice and meaning

Term	Definition	Do not confuse
Poetic speaker	The voice speaking in a lyric poem.	Not automatically the real poet.
Persona	A developed fictional role adopted by the speaker.	More specific than any speaking voice.
Subject	The broad topic.	Not yet a complete interpretive claim.
Theme	A developed idea or claim about the subject.	Usually expressible as a sentence.
Tone	The attitude conveyed toward subject or audience.	Not simply the reader's mood.

Prose, verse and blank verse

Form	Definition	Key distinction
Prose	Language without regular organisation into metrical verse lines.	Can occur in narrative and drama.
Verse	Language organised into lines, often with rhythmic or metrical patterning.	Need not rhyme.
Blank verse	Unrhymed iambic pentameter.	Regular metre, but no end rhyme.

Sonnets

Form	Structure	Typical pattern
English sonnet	14 lines: three quatrains and a final couplet.	ABAB CDCD EFEF GG
Italian sonnet	14 lines: octave and sestet.	Often ABBA ABBA CDE CDE; sestet varies.
Volta	A turn in thought, argument, tone or perspective.	Often at a major structural boundary.

Rhyme patterns

Term	Pattern	Meaning
Cross rhyme	ABAB	Lines 1 and 3 rhyme; lines 2 and 4 rhyme.
Enclosed rhyme	ABBA	Outer rhymes enclose the inner pair.
Couplet rhyme	AABB or AA	Adjacent lines rhyme in pairs.
Rhyme scheme	Letter notation such as ABAB.	Tracks end-rhyme relations.

5 - Meter, scansion and line movement

STRESS NOTATION

Use **x** for an unstressed syllable and **/** for a stressed syllable. A **foot** is the repeating rhythmic unit; **meter** is the organised pattern of feet across the line.

The four main feet

Foot	Pattern	Sound cue	Memory cue
Iamb	x /	da-DUM	Rising movement.
Trochee	/ x	DUM-da	Falling two-syllable movement.
Dactyl	/ x x	DUM-da-da	One stress followed by two unstressed syllables.
Anapest	x x /	da-da-DUM	Two unstressed syllables lead into a stress.

Counting feet

Name	Feet per line	Typical use
Dimeter	2	Two repeating feet.
Trimeter	3	Three repeating feet.
Tetrameter	4	Four repeating feet.
Pentameter	5	Five repeating feet; blank verse uses iambic pentameter.

A reliable scansion method

1. Read naturally and mark prominent stresses before forcing a pattern.
2. Divide the line into likely feet and identify the repeating pattern.
3. Count the feet to name dimeter, trimeter, tetrameter or pentameter.
4. Allow limited variation. A catalectic line may omit the final unstressed syllable.
5. State the dominant meter, then mention a meaningful deviation if necessary.

Line movement

Term	Definition	Decision rule
Enjambment	Syntax continues across the line break.	The grammatical unit remains incomplete at line end.
End-stopped line	A syntactic unit closes or strongly pauses at line end.	Use syntax, not punctuation alone.
Caesura	A strong pause within a verse line.	The interruption occurs inside the line.

6 - Rhetorical and sound devices

METHOD
Name the device only after identifying the textual relationship: association, comparison, sound imitation, direct address, repetition, contrast or reversal.

Device	Definition	Invented cue or example
Metonymy	Replacement through close association.	"The Crown" refers to the monarchy.
Metaphor	One thing is described as another without "like" or "as".	"Time is a thief."
Personification	Human qualities are given to a non-human entity or abstraction.	"The storm hammered angrily."
Onomatopoeia	A word imitates or evokes a sound.	buzz, hiss, crack
Apostrophe	Direct address to an absent person, abstraction or non-human entity.	"O Time, slow down!"
Parallelism	Repetition of a grammatical structure.	"To learn, to practise, to improve."
Antithesis	A contrast in meaning placed in parallel units.	"Many speak; few listen."
Chiasmus	Reversed parallel structure, often ABBA.	"We shape our tools; our tools shape us."
Anaphora	Repetition at the beginnings of successive units.	"We will learn. We will practise."
Alliteration	Repetition of initial consonant sounds.	"wild winds whistle"

High-risk distinctions

ANTITHESIS VS CHIASMUS

Antithesis depends on **contrast in meaning**. Chiasmus depends on **reversed structure**. One expression may contain both.

METONYMY VS METAPHOR

Metonymy uses **association**. Metaphor uses a **cross-domain comparison or identification**.

APOSTROPHE VS PERSONIFICATION

Apostrophe is **direct address**. Personification gives something **human qualities**. They can co-occur.

ANAPHORA VS PARALLELISM

Anaphora repeats an **opening word or phrase**. Parallelism repeats a **grammatical structure**.

7 - Drama: structure, speech and effects

Structure and page conventions

Term	Definition	Recognition cue
Act	A major division of a play, normally containing several scenes.	The largest conventional structural unit.
Scene	A subdivision of an act, often marked by changes in place or characters present.	A reference such as 2.3 means Act 2, Scene 3.
Dramatis personae	The list of characters, usually printed before the play.	Names and roles before Act 1.
Stage directions	Non-spoken instructions about movement, gesture, setting, sound or performance.	Enter, exit, pause, movement or scenic instruction.

Speech forms

Form	Definition	Difference
Dialogue	Words exchanged between two or more characters.	Alternating speakers respond to one another.
Monologue	An extended speech by one character; other characters may be present.	Defined mainly by length and one speaker.
Soliloquy	An extended speech revealing private thought, conventionally unheard by other characters.	Private reflection for the audience.
Aside	A brief remark intended for the audience but unheard by other characters.	Normally much shorter than a soliloquy.

Genre and audience effects

Term	Definition	Recognition cue
Tragedy	Serious conflict moving toward catastrophe, suffering or death.	Irreversible loss or disastrous resolution.
Comedy	Conflict moving toward resolution, reconciliation or reintegration.	Need not be continuously funny.
Dramatic irony	The audience knows more than a character.	A character acts on incomplete or false knowledge.
Satire	Critical exposure of vice, folly or corruption through ridicule or exaggeration.	Humour serves criticism.
Pun	Wordplay exploiting multiple meanings or similar sounds.	One expression activates two interpretations.

DRAMA LANGUAGE

Both prose and verse can occur in drama. Blank verse is specifically unrhymed iambic pentameter; prose is not organised into regular metrical verse lines.

8 - Cross-genre exam toolkit

Fast classification sequence

1. **Name the level.** Is the question about narrative voice, perception, character information, poetic form, sound, line movement or dramatic performance?
2. **Use the defining criterion.** Participation decides homo-/heterodiegetic; mind access decides focalization; syntax decides enjambment; information inequality decides dramatic irony.
3. **Separate nearby terms.** Story/plot/discourse, subject/theme, mystery/suspense, explicit/implicit and narratorial/figural are frequent distractor pairs.
4. **Apply to only the evidence given.** A self-contained example supplies everything needed; do not import plot knowledge from a literary work.
5. **Explain in one sentence.** Use the form: "This is X because the example shows defining feature Y."

Ten high-risk distinctions

Pair	First	Second
Story / plot	Chronological reconstruction.	Presented arrangement of events.
Plot / discourse	Event order and connection.	Broader manner of storytelling.
Narrator / focalizer	Who speaks?	Who perceives or knows?
Homo- / heterodiegetic	Narrator participates.	Narrator does not participate.
Internal / external focalization	Mind access.	Observable facts only.
Explicit / implicit	Trait stated.	Trait inferred.
Narratorial / figural	Source is narrator.	Source is character.
Subject / theme	Broad topic.	Claim about the topic.
Mystery / suspense	Missing past or present information.	Uncertain future outcome.
Enjambment / end-stopped	Syntax continues.	Syntax closes or strongly pauses.

NO TEXT MEMORISATION

The exam skill practised here is conceptual transfer: recognise a term from its defining feature and apply it to new material. The PDF contains no plot summaries, named passages or quotation-recall tasks.

Narrative glossary

Core = highest-priority exam vocabulary. Plus = useful supporting vocabulary. Definitions are intentionally text-independent.

Level	Term	Definition	Recognition cue
Plus	**Narrative**	A representation of connected events communicated by a narrating instance.	Look for events plus an act of telling or presentation.
Core	**Story**	The reconstructed chronological sequence of events: what happened first, next and last.	Put the events back into time order.
Core	**Plot**	The concrete arrangement and connection of events as presented in the text.	Ask in which order the reader receives the events.
Core	**Discourse**	The level concerned with the 'how'-the actual process and manner of storytelling.	Order, perspective, selection, presentation and language all belong here.
Core	**Narrator**	The voice or instance that tells the story.	Ask: Who speaks or tells?
Core	**Homodiegetic narrator**	A narrator who is also a character in the story being told.	Participation in the story world is decisive; first person is a common signal.
Core	**Heterodiegetic narrator**	A narrator who is not a character in the story world.	The narrating voice stands outside the represented events.
Plus	**Person**	The grammatical form of narration, typically first person (I/we) or third person (he/she/they).	Identify pronouns, then separately classify the narrator's position.
Core	**Focalization**	The selection and restriction of narrative information through a position of perception or knowledge.	Ask: Who perceives, knows, feels or reflects?
Core	**Focalizer**	The character or perceptual position through which narrative information is selected.	Find the consciousness whose knowledge limits the passage.
Core	**Internal focalization**	Narrative information is tied to the knowledge and perception of a particular character.	Thoughts, feelings, memories and perception verbs are strong signals.
Core	**External focalization**	Only externally observable behaviour or events are presented; no direct access to a character's mind is given.	Apply the camera test: could a camera record everything stated?
Plus	**Zero focalization**	The narrator provides more information than any single character could possess.	Unrestricted movement between minds, places or times is a common signal.
Core	**Narrative comment**	A mode in which the narrator interrupts or frames the action to offer thoughts, judgements or remarks about the telling.	Direct reader address such as 'Dear reader' is a strong signal.
Core	**Characterization**	The techniques by which a text provides information about a character.	Separate two axes: explicit/implicit and narratorial/figural.

Narrative glossary - continued

Core = highest-priority exam vocabulary. Plus = useful supporting vocabulary. Definitions are intentionally text-independent.

Level	Term	Definition	Recognition cue
Core	**Explicit characterization**	A character trait or quality is stated directly.	The text names the trait for the reader.
Core	**Implicit characterization**	Character information is conveyed indirectly and must be inferred from speech, action, appearance or surroundings.	Ask what the evidence suggests rather than what is directly stated.
Core	**Narratorial characterization**	Information about a character is supplied by the narrator.	Identify the source of the information: narrating voice.
Core	**Figural characterization**	Information about a character is supplied through a character in the story.	Self-description or one character describing another is figural.
Core	**Setting**	The spatial, temporal and often social environment in which the action takes place.	Ask where, when and under what social conditions.
Core	**Analepsis**	A backward movement in narrative time to an event earlier than the present point of narration.	Flashback.
Core	**Prolepsis**	A forward movement that anticipates or presents a later event.	Flash-forward or explicit anticipation.
Core	**Mystery**	A lack of information about identity, motive, place, time or the circumstances of an action.	Ask: What happened, who did it, or why?
Core	**Suspense**	The reader's feeling of uncertainty and anticipation while waiting for an outcome.	Ask: What will happen next?
Plus	**Modes of presentation**	Basic ways narrative information is presented, including report, description, comment and speech/dialogue.	Ask whether the text summarizes action, depicts features, comments or presents words.
Plus	**Free indirect discourse**	A character's idiom or viewpoint blends into third-person narration without a reporting clause or quotation marks.	Third person and past tense remain, but the sentence sounds like the character's thought.
Plus	**Interior monologue**	A direct presentation of a character's thoughts, commonly in first person and without an audible addressee.	The reader appears to hear the thought itself.
Plus	**Story time**	The duration of events in the represented story world.	How much time passes for the characters?
Plus	**Discourse time**	The time or textual extent required to present the narrative.	Compare reading time with the duration of events.

Poetry glossary

Core = highest-priority exam vocabulary. Plus = useful supporting vocabulary. Definitions are intentionally text-independent.

Level	Term	Definition	Recognition cue
Core	**Poetic speaker**	The voice that speaks in a lyric poem.	Ask who says 'I' inside the poem.
Core	**Persona**	A clearly fictional, developed role or identity adopted by the poetic speaker.	The speaker has a distinct invented situation or identity.
Core	**Subject**	The general topic or area a text is about, often expressible in one word or phrase.	Love, war, nature, memory.
Core	**Theme**	The central idea or claim a text develops about its subject.	Express it as a meaningful sentence, not a single topic word.
Core	**Tone**	The attitude or vocal inflection conveyed by a speaker, narrator or character toward a subject or audience.	Choose an adjective supported by diction: ironic, admiring, critical, melancholic.
Core	**Prose**	Language not regularly organized into metrical verse lines.	No regular verse-line organization.
Plus	**Verse**	Language organized into lines, often with rhythmic or metrical patterning.	Visible lineation plus poetic rhythm.
Core	**Blank verse**	Unrhymed iambic pentameter.	Five iambic feet, regular meter, no end rhyme.
Core	**Couplet**	Two verse lines that function together as a unit, often linked by end rhyme.	A two-line unit; the closing GG of an English sonnet is a couplet.
Core	**English sonnet**	A 14-line sonnet conventionally formed by three quatrains and a final couplet.	Typical rhyme scheme: ABAB CDCD EFEF GG.
Core	**Italian sonnet**	A 14-line sonnet conventionally divided into an octave and a sestet.	Typical opening scheme: ABBA ABBA; sestet patterns vary.
Core	**Volta**	A turn in thought, argument, tone or perspective within a sonnet.	Look for a structural or argumentative shift.
Core	**Rhyme scheme**	The ordered pattern of end rhymes represented by letters.	Give the same letter to lines with the same final rhyme sound.
Core	**Cross rhyme**	An alternating end-rhyme pattern: ABAB.	Lines 1 and 3 rhyme; lines 2 and 4 rhyme.
Core	**Enclosed rhyme**	A rhyme pattern in which the outer lines enclose the inner pair: ABBA.	First rhymes with fourth; second with third.
Core	**Couplet rhyme**	A paired rhyme pattern such as AABB, or one rhyming AA pair.	Adjacent lines rhyme in pairs.
Core	**Meter**	A patterned arrangement of stressed and unstressed syllables in verse.	Name the main foot plus the number of feet, such as iambic pentameter.
Core	**Foot**	The smallest recurring unit of poetic meter, usually containing two or three syllables.	Identify the stress pattern inside the unit.

Poetry glossary - continued

Core = highest-priority exam vocabulary. Plus = useful supporting vocabulary. Definitions are intentionally text-independent.

Level	Term	Definition	Recognition cue
Core	**Iamb**	A metrical foot consisting of an unstressed syllable followed by a stressed syllable: x /.	da-DUM.
Core	**Trochee**	A metrical foot consisting of a stressed syllable followed by an unstressed syllable: / x.	DUM-da.
Core	**Dactyl**	A metrical foot consisting of one stressed syllable followed by two unstressed syllables: / x x.	DUM-da-da.
Core	**Anapest**	A metrical foot consisting of two unstressed syllables followed by one stressed syllable: x x /.	da-da-DUM.
Core	**Enjambment**	The syntactic unit continues beyond the end of a verse line without a strong closing pause.	The sentence runs over the line break.
Core	**End-stopped line**	A verse line whose syntactic unit ends or strongly pauses at the line boundary.	Syntax, not punctuation alone, is decisive.
Core	**Metonymy**	One term is replaced by another closely associated with it.	Association rather than resemblance.
Core	**Onomatopoeia**	Words imitate or evoke the sounds they name.	The word itself sounds like the noise.
Core	**Apostrophe**	A direct address to an absent person, abstract idea or non-human entity.	Look for an explicit invocation such as 'O…'.
Core	**Parallelism**	The repetition of syntactic, grammatical or conceptual patterns.	Equivalent units share a similar structure.
Core	**Antithesis**	A contrast or opposition in meaning between parallel or adjacent units.	Meaning opposes meaning.
Core	**Chiasmus**	Parallel phrases or clauses reverse the order of corresponding elements: ABBA.	Look for structural crossing or inversion.
Core	**Personification**	Human qualities or actions are attributed to an animal, object or abstract concept.	Can the subject literally perform the human action?
Core	**Metaphor**	One thing is described or understood in terms of another without 'like' or 'as'.	Direct conceptual identification or transfer.
Core	**Alliteration**	The repetition of a consonant sound at the beginning of words or stressed syllables.	Listen to the opening sound, not merely the first letter.
Plus	**Anaphora**	The repetition of a word or phrase at the beginnings of successive lines, clauses or sentences.	Repeated opening.
Plus	**Caesura**	A pronounced pause within a line of verse.	The pause occurs inside, not at the end of, the line.

Drama glossary

Core = highest-priority exam vocabulary. Plus = useful supporting vocabulary. Definitions are intentionally text-independent.

Level	Term	Definition	Recognition cue
Core	**Act**	A major division of a play, normally containing several scenes.	The largest conventional structural unit of a drama.
Core	**Scene**	A subdivision of an act, often marked by changes in location or the characters present.	Act 1, Scene 2 is written 1.2.
Plus	**Dramatis personae**	The list of characters in a play, usually printed before the dramatic text.	Names and roles before Act 1.
Core	**Stage directions**	Non-spoken instructions concerning movement, gesture, setting, sound or performance.	Enter, exit, aside, movement or scenic instruction.
Core	**Dialogue**	Words exchanged between two or more characters.	Alternating speakers address and respond to one another.
Plus	**Monologue**	An extended speech by one character; other characters may be present and may hear it.	One speaker holds the floor for a sustained passage.
Core	**Soliloquy**	An extended dramatic speech in which a character voices private thoughts, conventionally unheard by other characters.	Private reflection spoken aloud for the audience.
Core	**Aside**	A brief remark intended for the audience or one character but conventionally unheard by the others on stage.	Short, secret communication within a scene.
Core	**Tragedy**	A dramatic genre presenting serious conflict that moves toward catastrophe, suffering or death.	The protagonist's conflict ends disastrously.
Core	**Comedy**	A dramatic genre in which conflict conventionally moves toward resolution, reconciliation or social reintegration.	The ending is structurally comic even if not every scene is humorous.
Core	**Dramatic irony**	The audience knows important information that one or more characters do not know.	Knowledge gap between audience and character.
Core	**Satire**	The critical exposure or ridicule of vice, folly or social corruption.	Humour or exaggeration serves criticism.
Plus	**Pun**	Wordplay exploiting multiple meanings or similar sounds.	One expression activates two interpretations.

Final concept-only self-check

Prompt	Answer
Chronological sequence of events?	**Story**
Order in which events are presented?	**Plot**
Narrator belongs to the story world?	**Homodiegetic narrator**
Only observable actions are reported?	**External focalization**
Trait must be inferred from behaviour?	**Implicit characterization**
Turn in a sonnet's thought?	**Volta**
Unrhymed iambic pentameter?	**Blank verse**
Syntax continues across the line break?	**Enjambment**
Extended private dramatic speech?	**Soliloquy**
Audience knows more than a character?	**Dramatic irony**

STOP RULE

If you can define the core terms, distinguish the common pairs and apply them to new examples, stop rereading. Redo weak questions instead.